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# Virginia Board of Education, Business Meeting, Thursday, July 23, 2020

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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=HpxprL7ccNg
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-24. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

**[00:01:11]** morning all hi pam how are you good how are you good good good it's hot today yes air still on the fritz so if i step over for a minute i'm getting a drink oh no i know i had my air conditioning go out sunday but it got fixed quickly that's good it's awful i don't do well

**[00:01:40]** in and high heat humidity me neither just let you know we are working on getting everything set up for live so not sure that we're fully alive yet but we are working on that good morning jamel

**[00:02:17]** dan hey good morning can you hear me yep great thank you um just so you know we're working on

**[00:04:50]** getting it set up live so that we're ready to go right at 10. that's fine i thought i saw a text or a chat that said we were alive oh maybe m just sent that 9 53. yep we are live so we'll give folks a little bit more time to hop on oh sure yeah we got some time yeah i'd just like to get in early

**[00:05:16]** make sure i don't have technical glitches i need to resolve morning jamel good morning

**[00:06:49]** sonia i'd like to say thank you ladies for taking such good care of me and making my life easier with all of these registrations for these virtual meetings thank you both very much happy to help

[00:07:11] you're welcome good morning good morning good morning and james keep expecting you to show up

[00:09:30] in the virginia's for learners t-shirt it has been known to be done yes we should have a uh

[00:09:49] board t-shirt day we should hey dan i think we're missing an is that right sorry i lost power for a

[00:11:38] minute but i'm back now um i do not see ann yet right okay oh wait a minute i was before i'm sure she'll be here oh there she is hi hello all right it's uh 10 o'clock i think the whole board is here emily any preliminary comments or can we get going i think we can get going hopefully i won't lose

[00:12:16] power but um if i do just keep moving along we'll go along without you sorry yeah sounds so sad okay uh we're gonna call the board of education meeting to order uh honestly i'm not sure i'm ever going to get used to this virtualness of it. I mostly hope I don't get used to it.

[00:12:40] I miss meeting in person and apparently you just changed the screen on me. So let me move these over to where I can actually see people. I'll take you down. That's all right. Keep doing that. All right. Welcome to the board's virtual meeting. Board members and staff are reaching a safe location for today's meeting, which is being streamed live on the VDOE YouTube channel and on the board's public meeting webpage. We'd like to welcome those joining us on the

[00:13:16] live stream from across the Commonwealth. A couple of things to note about the virtual meeting, which are different from when we're in person. Number one, the board accepted written public comment for this meeting. All comments that were received by 5 p.m. yesterday have been uploaded to our meeting webpage. Comments received after 5 p.m. will be provided to the board in a timely manner and posted on our meeting webpage. For those of you watching on YouTube, the chat feature is not being monitored by staff. The best way to contact the board is by email at BOE, as in

[00:13:50] Board of Education, at DOE, Department of Education, dot Virginia, dot gov. Since we are meeting virtually, there is a need for a roll call vote for each item. Please be sure to speak clearly so staff can accurately capture your vote for the meeting minutes. Okay, we'll do the roll call All first, Ms. Davis-Vaught.

[00:14:12] - Present. - Dr. Duran. - Present. - Ms. Holton. - Present. - Dr. Mann. - Present. - Dr. Pexton.

[00:14:27] - Present. - And Dr. Wilson. - I'm here. - Okay, and I am, of course, here. Next is the approval of minutes from the June 17 and 18 meetings of the board. Is there a motion to approve those minutes or is there a motion to approve with corrections?

[00:14:47] - Motion to approve. - Thank you, Dr. Durand, is there a second? - Second. - Thank you, Ms. Davis-Vaught, again by roll call. Ms. Davis-Vaught? - Aye. - Dr. Durand? - Aye. - Ms. Holton?

[00:15:02] - Aye. - Dr. Mann? - Aye. - Dr. Pexton? - Aye. - And Dr. Wilson? - Aye. - Okay, as you know, at the last meeting, the last meeting was the end of the term for our Vice President, Ms. Atkinson, who will be sorely missed, However, it is now time for the board to elect a new vice president to serve out the unexpired term, which will go to next June 30.

[00:15:34] Is there a nomination for the position of vice president of the Board of Education? President Gecker, I would like to make a nomination, sir. Yes, Ms. Davis-Vaugh. I would like to nominate Dr. Jamel Wilson to be the next vice president of the board.

[00:15:51] She's a very well-known and highly respected educator, formerly from Hanover County, and she's aspired to the University of Richmond, and her servant leadership capabilities are more than well documented. Thank you, Ms. Davis-Vaught. Is there a second?

[00:16:07] I would like to second that. Thank you, Dr. Pexton. Is there a motion to close nominations? I move to close nominations. Second to that. Second. A vote on the motion to close nominations. Ms. Davis-Vaught?

[00:16:23] Aye. Dr. Duran. Aye. Ms. Holton. Aye. Dr. Mann. Aye. Dr. Pexton. Aye. And Dr. Wilson. No, you can't recuse. Aye. Okay. And then the motion to elect Dr. Wilson as Vice President of the Board of Education.

[00:16:47] Miss Davis Vaught. Aye. Dr. Duran. Aye. Miss Holton. Aye. Dr. Mann. Aye. Dr. Pexton. Aye. Dr. Wilson. Aye. You can vote aye to that one. I was going to say, that's a little, yes, aye.

[00:17:08] Yeah, the chair will also vote aye to that. Let me just say for Dr. Wilson, a welcome addition to the leadership team of the board. You know, one of the neat things to me about this board is the diverse backgrounds that we have and bring to the work of promoting education in the Commonwealth.

[00:17:29] You know, as you've heard me say many times, I'm not in the education business by trade. I, you know, now I guess I'm more than dabbling in it, but it's been a learning experience for me over the past six years. Dr. Wilson brings to the leadership of the board, you know, not only a wealth of education experience, but a wealth of respect in the education community.

[00:17:53] And we expect you to do great things, you know, as we move forward. There's a lot of work to this, and you and I have had talks about this. I know you're up to it, and I very much look forward to finishing out my term as president with your help, assistance, and guidance.

[00:18:11] So thank you for agreeing to accept this. I have expected you not to show up for this meeting, but certainly glad you decided to make it to the call. And like I said, I am very, very pleased with this choice. So thank you again for agreeing to serve.

[00:18:28] You are welcome to say a few words if you would like, or we can move on if you prefer also. Well, I will just say very quickly, thank you all for your support and your confidence in my ability to work alongside you in this way.

[00:18:44] And I was thinking actually this week, this marks the beginning of my 30th year of working in or with public education directly. and i can't think of a better way for me to enter this third decade i can't believe i'm saying that uh third decade of service to the young people of the commonwealth of virginia so i'm very excited to be in this in this spot so thank you all very much yeah that leaves us to wonder how somebody who looks 26 30 years in the commonwealth yeah yeah i started i was a child protege prenatal

[00:19:22] protege all right right all right uh thank you uh the consent agenda we have two items on it is there a motion to either adopt the consent agenda as drafted or to remove an item for consideration by the board motion to accept thank you miss davis vaut is there a second second second thank you dr duran again roll call miss davis vaut dr duran hi miss holton hi dr man

[00:19:57] aye uh dr pexton aye and dr wilson aye and chair of force book all right action and discussion items item c uh first review of proposed amendments to regulations establishing standards for accrediting

public schools in virginia to comport with the 2020 legislation passed by the general assembly fast track uh my formerly favorite deputy secretary and now part

[00:20:28] of the department this coy is this you good morning everyone it's a pleasure to join you uh president gecker uh new others uh dr jillain pleasure to be with you this morning to present this item to you i don't know about the rest of you the audio for me is fairly uh broken up it is for me as well yes i think see what we can do i don't mean to interrupt you holly but it's

[00:21:05] important that people understand what it's been so okay um i will call in and see if we um do it that way too okay um that that's better already i think and okay and your video is now coming in too and i can stop that to assist with our internet issues all right uh so this morning the first item i have to present to you all uh is uh the first review of proposed amendments to the standards of accreditation to comport with a few pieces of legislation from the 2020 session there are a

[00:21:40] few items incorporated here and our recommendation ultimately is to wave first review and advance these regulations these adjustments to the soas via fast track regulation so the matter's at hand this morning there were two pieces of legislation house bill 516 and senate bill 112 that added dual enrollment to the type of advanced coursework that could be counted as a graduation requirement so previously the the graduation requirement was such that a student had to have ap ib or an honors

[00:22:18] course or earn a cte credential with this new legislation the options for a student are ap ib honors or dual enrollment or a high quality work based learning experience as defined by the board or a cte credential so it expands those options for students to to meet those requirements and and gives them some new opportunity while embedding the work-based learning as a priority of the

[00:22:51] boards. So that is the first part of the edits to the SOAs. The second bill that this item incorporates is Senate Bill 323 and this requires that in the graduation requirements a student pursuing an advanced diploma whose IEP specifies credit accommodations for world language that that student be able to substitute two credits in computer science for the two credits in world language in addition to that the school counselor must advise the student and their family and

[00:23:27] notify them of any impact that this might have on college applications and their ability to compete in those college applications this second item was a matter of greater debate with the general assembly and you see that second piece about the counselor being engaged in advising the student because of some of the concerns about the impact that that might have on a student's ability to compete or to be accepted at a higher ed institution if they don't have those world language credits. So again, happy to dive into more detail or answer additional questions,

[00:24:04] but the recommendation is to waive first review and approve the regulations for fast track. President Gecker? Thank you, figured that out. Does the board have any questions first?

[00:24:23] i have a question that is not um going to it's just a curiosity that i'd like to register here as we're thinking about expanding or we'll be expanding the regulations or the requirements for an advanced diploma it would be curious to know how many graduates actually we are now who would now qualify for that advanced diploma by expanding to cte high quality experience cte sequence um and all of the other pieces i would be curious to know what percentage of our students

[00:24:58] are now actually receiving an advanced diploma and then perhaps even asking the question you know may lead us to a question about the the levels of diplomas or the different diplomas that we

actually have so that's just something to maybe table for later yep we can certainly call that does anybody else have any question of ms coy i don't see anybody and therefore is there a motion to waive first review and adopt the proposed amendments so moved thank you dr wilson is there

[00:25:36] a second second thank you dr duran uh again by roll call miss davis fought dr duran hi miss holton aye dr mann aye dr pexton aye dr wilson aye and i vote aye okay uh item d first first review of resolution prescribing the standards of quality for public schools in virginia um miss coy wonderful uh so in this item what we have for your consideration is a resolution uh from the board um

[00:26:12] reaffirming and receiving uh and and really re-prescribing the standards of quality for public schools in virginia that align with the actions that you all took last fall and the resolution itself is pretty simple and straightforward reaffirming the work that the board undertook in the process the priorities of the comprehensive plan noting that the standards of quality were prescribed by the board of education last year were not funded and therefore we were prescribing those same standards again.

[00:26:51] All right. I'm going to address this just for a minute because this may have been promoted by me to be on this agenda. You know, last year for the first time in two decades, the board took the constitutionally mandated step of prescribing SOQs for the Commonwealth. The way the process used to work is that those standards of quality would be undertaken by the legislature and either revised or not not revised although there was never a case i think where they were not revised

[00:27:24] in some fashion by the assembly uh this past year as most of you know what happened is we had two bills carrying uh the soqs one in the house one in the senate uh neither of them really made up to the appropriations committee. We got out of the education committees, but then sort of died. That may or may not have constituted the constitutionally mandated process of revision.

[00:27:52] We're going to assume for the moment that it did, and therefore, you know, our need to re-prescribe, if you will, becomes present. The reason that we're doing first review instead of going right to prescribing is to afford the board the opportunity to look at them again and to decide if there are any changes we want to make. I frankly have not seen any that I want to make but to open it up to the board and so that the public can comment. You know the intent is not to pass it today but to go ahead

[00:28:32] and move it to the September meeting. This also puts us more in line with the legislative calendar and will give us an opportunity to perhaps speak more fully to more legislators prior to session. You know, I don't know if there are any questions of either me, Dr. Lane, or Ms. Coy on this, but that's sort of, you know, what we're doing and why we're doing it. Since I don't see anything, Dr. Paxton? I was just going to maybe just affirm that I think

[00:29:09] the timeline and the timing of this, I think it's appropriate considering some of our other work, you know, looking at the standards of accreditation and that during those discussions, referencing the standards of quality. So I think it makes sense even based on our discussions yesterday that the approach that you're proposing is appropriate for us to take some time to take one more look at. For those members of the press who cover this, the SOQs seem to always get

[00:29:43] reported in terms of dollars as opposed to in terms of policy. And I would like to point out that if you read through the SOQs described by the board last year and under discussion for this year, there are distinct policy changes embedded in these standards of quality from the current standards. And those policy changes or that policy direction is worthy of some note study and discussion in the legislature.

Anybody else have any comments on this? Mr. President? Yes, yes, ma'am. So first, thank you for bringing this to us. I did have some questions about

[00:30:23] why we need to re-prescribe, but you and I have talked and I'm satisfied that your analysis makes sense and so I am supportive of the effort to re-prescribe and I think that I see no reason to to change our underlying recommendations and so I'm supportive I have one or two possible small wording changes that I may take up with you between now and the next board meeting but nothing that we need to hash

[00:30:58] out here great thank you anybody else okay uh we will move on then and we'll take that under first review uh item e first review of proposed amendment to the regulations governing the employment of professional personnel to comport with legislation passed by the 2020 general assembly this one's yours i think yes good morning president gecker members of the board and dr lane this regulatory amendment will be filed as an exempt action because a revision is required by legislation

[00:31:35] of the General Assembly. House Bill 365 and Senate Bill 98 passed by the 2020 General Assembly amended the Code of Virginia to one, remove the option for local school boards to extend the three-year probationary period of service for teachers by up to two additional years and remove the prohibition against school boards re-employing any teacher whose performance evaluation during the probationary term of service is unsatisfactory the board of education's

[00:32:11] regulations governing the employment of professional personnel must be amended to comport with this legislation the board of education the board is requested to wait first review and approve the proposed amendment to the regulations governing the employment of professional personnel to conform with legislation passed by the 2020 General Assembly. Thank you. Are there any questions here?

[00:32:42] I don't see any. So is there a motion then to waive first review and read the proposed amendment to the regulations governing the employment of professional personnel? So moved to waive first review and approve the amendment to comport with the legislation. Second. You're a second. Second.

[00:33:11] Thank you, Dr. Wilson. Again, by roll call, Ms. Davis-Vaught. Aye. Dr. Duran. Aye. Ms. Holton. Aye. Dr. Mann. Aye. Dr. Pexton. Aye. Dr. Wilson. Aye. And I vote aye. Okay, item F. Thank you. Thank you very much, Patty. First review of guidance and model policy for the notification of protective orders in public elementary and secondary schools uh dr hollins this is you yes good morning

[00:33:47] president gecker vice presidents and members of the board and dr lane i'm glad to be with you this morning to present for your first review our guidance and model policy for the notification of protective orders in public elementary and secondary schools this guidance was put forth as one of our deliverables from the 2019 general assembly session and as you can tell from our guidance document this is something that many schools have dealt with and have policies and practices to support however this legislation was really important in affording the Virginia Department of Education and the board and adopting these guidelines to provide opportunities for very formalized

[00:34:25] guidance around a very important topic related to student safety as well as providing an opportunity to share various sample plans and information materials that school divisions can use to carry out this really important task in a way that is easily understandable to them as you see in the document that we provide you the goal of this document is really to serve to support school divisions receiving those

court orders and in processing information that's integral to the safety of students everything from notification of staff to the development of student support plans as well as guidance and information related to confidentiality and FERPA you'll see that most of the guidance

[00:35:03] document is used for appendices that provide sample forms for divisions to use for this process and so we make it really easy for them to ensure that there's policies, practices, and procedures in effect to ensure the safety and security of their staff and students. And I just want to say thank you so much to our staff of my Office of Student Services. Gwen is joining me today on the call, but there was a lot of stakeholder support for this work. We brought together numerous representatives in order to make sure we got this really important task correct. So at this point, happy to pause for any questions related to your first review and the recommendation from the

[00:35:36] superintendent is to receive this information for first review. Are there any questions for Dr. Hollins? I have one question. Dr. Duran? Dr. Hollins, thank you for that. Was there any feedback received from any of the stakeholder groups that was not included and what was that, if there was? Great question, Dr. Duran. No, we actually invited numerous groups of interested parties to help us collaborate on this process and as you can tell from the background spent a lot of time digging into the important factors that can really comprise this

[00:36:12] information and so you'll see that we not only had representatives from the department of juvenile justice and our dcjs components but we also had some private organizations that are interested particularly in the protection of students and family rights as well as numerous school divisions that really have diverse areas of interest and exposure to this issue. And so I'm happy to report that via the stakeholder process, we received some really positive responses on the development of this document and have not received any subsequent public comment or information, but look forward to receiving that in between this review and your final review and considering that as necessary.

[00:36:48] Thank you. And when we do our final review, if you do get any public comment during the 30-day window that is not incorporated. I would appreciate just knowing what that was and why we did not include that. Thank you. Absolutely. I'm sure that you all have that information. Okay. Any other questions for Dr. Hollins? If not, the board will accept this item for first review. Thank you very much. Thank you. Okay. Adam G., first review of proposed state-approved textbooks for K-12 science.

[00:37:20] Ms. Peterson? Good morning, Mr. Gecker, members of the board and Dr. Lange. My name is Ann Peterson, and I am the science coordinator in the Office of STEM and Innovation. I am joined today by Meyer Thayer, our science specialist, to present a first review of the proposed state-approved textbooks for K-12 science. As you know, it is the responsibility of the board to approve textbooks for use in Virginia schools. These textbooks should align with the state's academic standards to ensure a solid foundation for student success. The current list of state-approved textbooks was

[00:37:54] approved by the board in 2012 following adoption of the 2010 Science Standards of Learning and Curriculum Framework. In September 2018, the Board of Education approved the 2018 Science Standards of Learning and Curriculum Framework. Local school divisions are expected to fully implement the 2018 Science Standards of Learning during the 2021-2022 academic year and are awaiting a board approved list of textbooks in order to adopt and purchase the textbooks necessary for their divisions. The Department of Education is bringing a list of proposed textbooks, K-12 science

[00:38:33] textbooks, to the board today for first review. The Department of Education began the process of review of the science textbooks following the Board of Education's approval in July 2019. The Department of Education executed the state review process and criteria approved using the timeline included in attachment A of the agenda item provided. In 2019 of October 2019, the VDOE invited publishers to submit textbooks for review and sought nominations for qualified educators to

[00:39:07] serve on the textbook review committees. In November 2019, the VDOE reviewed publisher certifications and agreements from nine publishers and 75 science textbooks spanning kindergarten through physics a blank copy of the publisher certification and agreement form is included in attachment c of the agenda item provided in november 2019 the videoe selected 27 textbook review committee members which consisted of a diverse group of classroom teachers and science supervisors the review committee is constructed of teachers and science leaders from across the

[00:39:46] Commonwealth, representing both rural and urban school divisions, and also diverse in terms of race, gender, and years of teaching experience. At this time, I'd like to thank the review committee for the time and diligence that each member provided reviewing and analyzing science textbooks.

[00:40:03] These Virginia educators are a vital part of the review process. In order to be environmentally conscious, the VDO requested that the publishers send information concerning virtual access to the textbooks being considered for approval to the reviewers in December of 2019. Little did we know how much this virtual component would work to our benefit later on. Committee members participated in virtual meetings with VDOE staff in January 2020 to review the process and criteria to be used in evaluating

[00:40:39] these textbooks. The evaluation criteria used for the science textbook review is included in attachment b of the agenda item provided these evaluation criteria included boe approved textbook review criteria which includes a section on reviewing content accuracy and bias as well as additions that align to the use of the science and engineering practices and the big ideas about science reflected in the 2018 science standards of learning these practices and big ideas were included in the revised standards to support the instruction for all students so that they can have the foundation and skills needed to become informed

[00:41:18] and scientifically literate graduates. From January to March 2020, members of the review committee used the evaluation criteria to independently review the textbooks for standards of learning correlations, content bias, and design for instructional support and planning.

[00:41:36] The review team electronically submitted their analyses of each textbook to the VDOE. In April 2020, VDOE staff aggregated the input of the committee members and shared the findings with the publishers. The publishers then responded to those comments at the beginning of June, and the review committees looked at the publishers' responses. During June and early July, consensus meetings were held with the various review committees to make final recommendations.

[00:42:04] Based on the committee's reviews, two publishers withdrew a total of eight textbooks from consideration. In addition, publishers did modify textbooks within the parameters of the BOE textbook approval process as suggested by review team members. An example of this occurred in the K-2 text as reviewers did not feel the books included diverse backgrounds within the images of the book. The textbook company changed images within the text to represent a greater degree of diversity. A list of 53 proposed science textbooks recommended for approval is included in attachment

[00:42:42] g of the agenda item provided the list includes nine publishers the check mark under the yes column of the document indicates the publishers of each textbook being proposed for approval as satisfactorily completed a publisher certification and agreement form all of the textbooks have been digital versions although some offer print versions of the textbooks as well some publishers also offer kits and materials with teacher ancillary documents to support instruction, these kits were not reviewed as part of the textbook review process.

[00:43:15] Access information has been included for these books for public comment. Upon the Board of Education's accepted of this proposed list of textbooks for further first review, a 30-day public comment period will be announced. Public review will be conducted using a virtual platform and all student versions of text can be accessed through the VDOE website, which will be made active at the conclusion of this meeting. In addition, the public review will be announced through a sups memo and through vdoe communication platforms department of education will review all public comment and report the findings to the board as they consider the list

[00:43:54] of textbooks for final review in september of 20 000 or 2020. i'd like to thank you for your courteous attention and consideration the superintendent of public instruction recommends that the board receive the first review for first review the attached list of proposed recommended textbooks for k-12 science at this time i would be happy to answer any questions you may have are any questions no not a question but just a comment mr becker sure please dr peterson thank

[00:44:27] you for the overview i i know the work that is involved in reviewing textbooks and um ensuring that the the set the list um is appropriate and meets all of the expectations so i certainly appreciate the work of your leadership and your team and all of those who've been involved to this point so thank you for that thank you i also would like to say thank you dr peterson and to my friend myra who's on thank you we worked together years ago and appreciate the comprehensive

[00:45:01] overview and the work that's been done particularly around being sensitive to the various um equitable views of the materials and making sure we're inclusive and i really appreciated you sharing that and i look forward to seeing if there's any comment just like in the last item if there's any public comment that's submitted before our action of the september 17th we'd love to hear what that might be and particularly if it was something that we didn't incorporate in any way so i'd love to hear that but thank you dr peterson and thank you myra for your work appreciate it

[00:45:32] and everyone else i just happen to know myra yes mr president may i so yes i'll echo the thanks and the appreciation for all the hard work that's gotten us to this stage and I appreciate your comments this morning explaining that there has been a focus on diversity and inclusion in the reviewers and in the content I do want to raise a concern and I'm realize I'm raising this late in the game and wish I

[00:46:07] had thought to raise it earlier but here we are recognizing that we only do this every seven plus years I don't feel comfortable not raising this now that I that we do not looking at the rubric if I understand correctly by which the reviewers have judged these textbooks there is nothing no no criteria in the rubric that and which apparently we adopted at some point in the past as part of our textbook review process so it wasn't it was our omission and not anybody else's but there is nothing in

[00:46:46] the rubric that says we should be judging these textbooks based on equity and inclusion and so for instance there's nothing no criteria that tells the textbook producers and the reviewers that we want to be sure that we're including pictures of women physicists and work by African American biologists etc etc

and I think that that's really especially important in our lower grades when we're looking to inspire children

[00:47:21] from all backgrounds to stem careers so this isn't just you know there is a there is an item in the rubric that materials consistently present content in an accurate, unbiased manner. You know, when you're getting into the high school textbook, maybe mostly about objective science that isn't affected by any of that, but especially in the lower grades, you know, these textbooks are really no different than the history and social studies in the sense that we need to be looking at them with our equity and inclusion lens in a very formal,

[00:47:58] explicit way. So I would like to recommend that two things. One, Mr. President, I would like to ask that we ask the department to help initiate a process to review the rubric before the next round of textbook review to fix the rubric, to add an equity and inclusion piece. And that we today ask the board that we as a board commit to include equity and inclusion in our review and that we ask Miss Peterson and her colleagues when we come

[00:48:37] back in September between now and when we come back in September essentially to do a supplemental review and it sounds like you all have done much of that already but if you can document to us that you are that you have reviewed the 30-some textbooks here I didn't even look maybe it's more than that across all the grades there's a lot of them that you all have reviewed those textbooks with an equity and inclusion lens and that you're satisfied they all meet at least minimum expectations on that and if not to flag to us any any

[00:49:15] concerns about any that don't and I would also like to invite the public specifically to focus on that as you look at the textbooks and let us know if you see concerns you know as I say we think about this with the history and social studies textbooks and SOLs on a regular basis maybe not as much as we should have but we need to think about it with all of our materials and and the the last thing I'd like to toss out really to my to my fellow board members is we've had board members in the past who were so diligent in reviewing materials I think particularly of

[00:49:56] Jim and Elizabeth Lodl and and Diane that I will confess I haven't always reviewed the textbooks myself there are a lot of them we've had staff review them we've had great panels of reviewers review them but I do feel like it's part of our responsibility at the board as a board to at least try to lay eyes on on them before we finally vote and I'm even you know thinking there's a lot of them so I'm wondering if we may be able to confer our amongst ourselves in in in two by two but in divide and

[00:50:32] conquer a little bit I'd be willing to look at the I'm not competent to look at the high school science textbooks I'm sure but to look at the elementary books and somebody else look at the middle and I can't promise I'll read every page of everyone but I feel like we should at least take the opportunity to to look at them in order to be able to fulfill our responsibilities so maybe we can do a little divide and conquer on that if if folks are interested I'd be happy to help one by one coordinate that a little bit and and we can just do that on our um but i'd love to hear miss peterson whether you all can help us

[00:51:12] you know a somewhat more formal supplemental review on equity and inclusion before our september vote oh yes we'd be very happy to do that um and perhaps come up with some guiding questions through both the vcu and the department of policy equity and communication that we can use to um look at the textbooks through the lens of equity and diversity and if you all could use that as a way to jump start a process for textbook review more generally

[00:51:45] i'd be the most grateful yeah no problem any other comments with regard to the textbooks we'll say i appreciate your comments i'm honestly not sure i'm confident to review any of the science but you know it's interesting that you bring up i know jim used to review the civics and elizabeth some of the history but i don't recall i guess i haven't been on the board long enough to have been through a review cycle for science yet so uh i'm you know i know when we

[00:52:22] talked about reviewing the actual books last time i mean there was like a whole room of them i mean they were voluminous is it really practical for us to review them well i think that's an excellent question and and the answer is no and that's why we have a process and we we don't have the expertise and we don't have the time and and what and really the best thing for us to do as a board is to set up a good and fair process to get good review by competent reviewers.

[00:52:54] And that's what we have done, and that's what Ms. Peterson and team have done. But I still feel like if we're approving them, we ought to crack the books at least a little bit as part of our oversight responsibilities. And the good news is that because of the electronic access, It will be easier for us now than it might have been in the past when we had to come into the board office to actually see hard copies.

[00:53:24] It will be easier for the public. So I hope we widespread use this opportunity to communicate widely to the public the opportunity and that hopefully we'll get good feedback from them. But that maybe between us, as I say, Mr. Gecker, we can agree to at least crack the books.

[00:53:44] And there may be some obvious things that jump out at us. Hopefully, it will all be great. As I understand one thing, you know, the list is all recommended, yes. And so you wonder a little bit, well, you know, are we exercising any real, you know, are the reviewers exercising sufficient, working diligently enough if everything passes?

[00:54:09] But Ms. Peterson has helped me understand that no, not everything passed, basically. Anything that came up with a no ended up withdrawing or being modified. So I'm satisfied we have a competent review process, but I just think to fulfill our responsibilities, we ought to have at least a little effort to open the books.

[00:54:35] - Mr. President, I'd like to just build on that a little bit, and maybe because I do feel like it's challenging because the work of the department is a work that's always in process, regardless of what board is seated and active at a given point in time.

[00:54:53] And perhaps there might be a way to appreciate a variety of rubrics that are used in the department's work, whether it's related to textbooks or other areas that really should have some attention to a lens of equity and inclusion, just as a part of trying to be ahead of those things that as work is moving forward there's a way to have those considerations infused because really when things come to the board at this point they come to the board having gone through a fairly

[00:55:26] lengthy process of work with a variety of stakeholders and i certainly i certainly would would value from a from a broader policy frame having an opportunity to make certain that the things that are of concern and the tools that are being used to set things in motion that as a board there's an opportunity to to shape that right because then that that informs work that flows through these very deliberative processes that are built into the department's efforts so

[00:56:01] i just offer that as something to contemplate you know we may be too far down the pike on the on this effort unless it can be delayed but i do i do offer that as something to to be mindful of that's an

excellent point uh you know our job i think is to shape the system and then the outcome as it flows through the system hopefully will be moved toward the goals uh we have set for the system uh and i think that gets to miss holton's point about uh you know it would be interesting to

[00:56:38] see what the rubric is so that we understand you know how these books were filtered and this is not at all you know i wish this discussion were happening independent of the review of the science books because it's not at all related to this specific topic it's related to the board's responsibilities overall uh you know and i have no doubt that uh you know dr peterson and you know everybody else did what they were supposed to do within the guidelines that are set forth so take this discussion move it independent of science for a minute i think and in a lot of things we do

[00:57:17] you know our approach should be to look at the system uh and to try to move the systems that the department uses to bend it toward as i said the goals we have you know one of the things we did in 17 that i thought was most effective was the revision of the comprehensive work plan to be much more specific than it had been in the past so that the department understood the direction the board was headed and more things got filtered through the lens that the board, you know, wanted to be filtered through. I will say that even after, what, six years of doing this or whatever

[00:57:52] it's been, five at least, you know, the vastness of the number of things that the department does moving the educational system forward is, you know, pretty significant. And, you know, the approach we have taken in the last three years at least has been a major systemic change first which is the policies as we talked briefly about before invited in the soqs which took give or take three years to get to and then uh i wouldn't say tinkering around the edges but other

[00:58:30] things like textbook review have been a little bit further down our priority list in terms of system review. Now that the SOQ policies are pretty much established by the board and expect to be reaffirmed next month, I think it more than appropriate for us to move into other areas that shape the system overall, textbooks being among those. I have had, and I'm not going to speak for James, I'm going to ask him to speak a little bit to this, there have been some discussions about

[00:59:05] you know, how much longer we're going to be using textbooks and running the review process at all. You know, our right to review textbooks, as was pointed out in the item, you know, is constitutional. Last time I asked about it during the history or excuse me, the civics, I guess, I was told we do it so that the locals don't have to because the cost to some of the smaller jurisdictions would be large. But I know, James, and I don't want to put you on the spot here, But you'd express some thoughts about, you know, where the department might be going long term in the area of textbooks and textbook review.

[00:59:44] Do you want to speak to that or would you prefer that that stay offline for a while? No, we were chatting before the meeting with staff, hoping that this question would be asked. So thank you. The Constitution actually gives the board broader authority than just textbooks.

[01:00:02] What it says is that the board has authority to approve textbooks and instructional aids and material for use in courses in the public schools of the Commonwealth. And so the board over time has overemphasized textbooks and de-emphasized your role in instructional aids and materials.

[01:00:22] And because of that, even throughout the code, textbooks have a heavy emphasis. And so we were really viewing the science textbook adoption as an end point to a more traditional approach to this.

[01:00:37] And as we adopt future standards in the future, we're hoping to take a focus on high-quality instructional materials rather than just textbooks alone. Now, some textbooks could be adopted as part of high-quality instructional materials, as Mr. Gecker mentioned, to help with our school divisions that need that support from a procurement standpoint.

[01:01:00] But what we're hoping to do is develop and procure and promote and approve, with the board's support, what we think are the best materials that could be used, not just materials that are acceptable.

[01:01:16] There's a growing body of evidence that high quality instructional materials actually has a huge impact on student achievement. And so we are in the process now of designing a plan. And so the questions that you've asked about Ms. Holton's questions about ensuring bias, Dr. Mann's questions about how we can ensure the board sees the process, we do hope to do that following the science textbook review.

[01:01:43] But we wanted to finalize this one process that was already well down the road and hope to spend some time with you on that, somewhat side by side with the SOA review, so that you'll have a process that you feel comfortable with. And we have a process that we feel is actually putting materials that are of value to schools in their hands.

[01:02:04] Thank you. One other point, Mr. Gecko, and that is it's probably good for the board to know that fewer and fewer teachers are actually using textbooks. It is more often than not now that our teachers are developing materials from other locations.

[01:02:22] The textbook is, I'm not saying it's not used in the Commonwealth because it is, but it is more often than not rarely used than the central piece of the curriculum. Yeah, thank you for that.

[01:02:38] Any other comments on this topic? I know we're sort of strayed from the specific science topic, but, you know, the generalized topic here. Okay, Dr. Peterson, thank you very much.

[01:02:54] It's always nice for me to see happy people come before us. I will say the science group seems to be always happy to be here, so I appreciate that. Well, thank you for allowing us to present. And look forward to seeing you, I guess, in September.

[01:03:12] Okay. All right. The written report update on early childhood ed. I thought I saw Ms. Conway. I don't know if we have any questions about the report. I don't see any. So we will push on from there. We are down to discussion of current issues by

[01:03:45] Board of Ed members and the superintendent. Is everybody else getting that feedback or is that just on mine? You are too? Yeah. I'll work to mute some lines. We can ask everyone to mute and then I'll get some others on there. Perfect. Thank you. All right. Discussion of current issues.

[01:04:14] You know, I don't have anything particularly specific to discuss. You know, interesting for us to have a board meeting that consists, you know, of relatively routine items at a time when, you know, the Commonwealth is trying to figure out how to open its schools.

[01:04:31] I'm going to ask Dr. Lane to talk about that for a minute. I will say that, you know, it is a particular concern to me to watch how divisions are doing this individually. I am very concerned about the increasing divide between the haves and the have nots in the Commonwealth. We're already seeing locally here at least, you know, talk of anecdotal, and I think will bear out, you know, in terms of evidence, a migration from the public schools of those who can

[01:05:05] either by going private or by, you know, there's an article the other day about, you know, groups hiring teachers to come in and teach separately. We're aware that in jurisdictions even that are going all virtual, there is a, in all cases, a divide between those who have appropriate equipment and those who don't. There's a divide between those who have the family ability to assist in that virtual education and those who don't. You know, there's been significant

[01:05:38] now discussion about the slide backward from not being physically present in schools. That will be exacerbated by this and although interestingly enough as the theory the commonwealth's policy body for education we have not been particularly involved in this process i know from his role as you know superintendent of public instruction dr lane has been but the board itself really hasn't been but there will be issues potentially in the future uh that will come

[01:06:12] before us discussions about how accreditation is going to be handled. And I know, you know, waivers and things like that right now rest with the superintendent, potentially for things like seat time. But the board ought to be thinking forward about when the emergency powers are rolled back and more flows back to the board, how we are thinking about it, we'll think about addressing this and what the policies ought to be. You know, we have stressed greatly in the work plan and the SOQs our desire to educate all children in the Commonwealth, not just those

[01:06:52] children who have the, you know, are fortunate enough to have the capability, you know, at home of having this occur in the way it ought to. We take that obligation and that, you know, frankly, right seriously. I'm not yet sure how we interpose ourselves here and how we make those policies known, but I would like to hear some feedback first from James, if that's okay, and then from the board members, if you feel it appropriate to talk about, you know, where do we think we're going? This is a day-to-day, this is, this may be the most critical topic in education we have right

[01:07:27] now. So Dr. Lane, I don't know if you want to respond to that. I know I'm putting you on the spot just a little bit uh but you know it's nothing you and i haven't talked about at least you know around the edges yeah thank you mr gecker happy to uh uh share some thoughts and certainly uh more than prepared to talk about this this is something that we spend all day every day thinking about uh at the department of education um i thought maybe i'd start with just making sure the board knows generally where we are around the state and uh and then some thoughts on

[01:08:07] how I think the board can play a very strong role in some of this decision making but we're the the state issued our guidance on how schools should open in a three-phase process in early June we've only made one change to that phase guidance since the since the governor released it originally and the health commissioner and I sent a letter to all school divisions on July 6th that essentially moved from where we were recommending six-foot distancing in every class to allowing school

[01:08:43] divisions to go as low as three-foot physical distancing if they add other mitigation measures like a face covering for students. But really, other than that one change, the phase guidance that came out in June has been in front of our school divisions for six weeks. Our phase guidance is extremely detailed. It's actually more detailed than many states around the nation.

[01:09:07] And the governor created metrics that allowed us to move from each phase. We are in phase three now, and phase three recommends in-person instruction for all students as long as they meet the mitigation strategies that are outlined in the phase guidance.

[01:09:27] But from the beginning, we have said that school divisions could be more restrictive than our guidance if local health conditions demanded it. And since entering phase three, not just in Virginia, but around the nation, we've seen increasing case prevalence.

[01:09:46] And many of our school divisions have become really concerned that their local data is suggesting a more restrictive approach. And so what we've seen is a number of school divisions, starting primarily in suburban and urban communities at first, and that has even grown from there.

[01:10:05] but many of our school divisions choosing a virtual option and what we're finding is more often than not some of our smaller and rural school divisions are continuing with an in-person option but most of them are doing some type of either staggered or hybrid approach or additional mitigation to get students in school. There are only a handful of school divisions that are actually

[01:10:33] promoting about five days a week. And so the decision on how to open schools is ultimately left to local communities because the local circumstances around the data is very different.

[01:10:52] But the guidance from the department and the metrics that the governor sets into phase three you know, are there. And so, you know, in all of our phases, we recommend at least some in-person instruction. In phase one, we recommend in-person instruction for students with disabilities.

[01:11:13] In phase two, we recommend in-person instruction for K-2 students and English language learners. And in K-3, we recommend in-person instruction for every student. But again, we've seen a trend where our teachers are very scared, and rightfully so, with cases increasing. And so, you know, the department is certainly supportive of our local community's decision to be more measured where it's appropriate. And then that becomes somewhat difficult because on the whole, we're

[01:11:49] finding that many, many parents are, you know, grasping and hungry for students to get back into a traditional classroom environment. And so we're working closely with our school districts. I still meet with our superintendents every week. Our superintendents have asked for more detailed metrics. We're working closely with the Virginia Department of Health now to roll out more detailed metrics that can guide their decision making. And so we will continue to give our school divisions whatever they need to make their decisions. But, you know, this is a very difficult time for our

[01:12:29] school leaders. I hope that everyone knows how much we appreciate the work that our superintendents and our school boards are doing. And with difficult decisions in front of them, the department will continue to provide the resources that they need to make decisions.

[01:12:45] And certainly our local health departments and our state health department are key partners and ultimately determining those metrics and helping to further define our guidance so that we can help schools get back to opening. I don't think there's a superintendent or a school board in the Commonwealth that doesn't want in-person instruction. Everybody wants to see students in person. But what I do know is that with the fears in the community, certainly the fears continuing to expand across the Sun Belt and the nation, we're finding more often than not our communities

[01:13:22] are taking a more cautious approach than what's in our guidance. James, are you seeing the same reluctance to go back in the private schools? So thus far, we're finding that our private schools are indicating that they're going to be more aggressive about an in-person opening for students.

[01:13:47] And what role do you see the board playing, if any, as we move forward? Yeah, thank you. So even though the General Assembly has given the superintendent broad flexibility to do waivers, and I've discussed this with Mr. Gecker, I think some of the bigger decisions shouldn't rest solely with the superintendent, and we're going to take some of the bigger decisions and make sure that there's a public process to collaborate with the board, and I'll define some of those in a minute. But one of the things that is not allowed is, whereas I'm pretty much able to waive anything

[01:14:26] to make our school division lives easier in the context of the pandemic. The department and the superintendent are not allowed to create new rules and there will definitely need to be a look at certain regulations that don't need to be waived but actually need to be enhanced or tweaked to make this process more efficient or even more appropriate for our students. And so some of the bigger Other decisions that we will be discussing in the near future is whether or not we want

[01:15:05] to seek a waiver of, for instance, the testing system. Right now the federal government has not allowed an application for a waiver of the federal testing system, though some states like Georgia have submitted a waiver anyways.

[01:15:21] We've not heard any feedback on whether Georgia's will be approved. far, the U.S. Department of Education has basically let us know that testing is not on the table. Certainly, if that comes on the table, that's a conversation we would have. A conversation we hope to have with the board is around the accreditation system. I have told superintendents that if we open in phase three, where students aren't in school every day, it's probably appropriate to waive accreditation another year. And so I'd love to hear even today some feedback

[01:16:00] from the board on that, because that would be one we might want to act on sooner than later. And then probably the big one that I want to talk about with the board is the waiver of the 180 and 990 clock hour requirement. You have delegated that authority to me, but that delegation was in the context of specific circumstances, and, you know, that I think the intent of your delegation of that to me was because these questions might need to be decided at the end of the year in a manner that school divisions can't wait for the board, but now we know really from day one we're

[01:16:40] going to have some need for waivers at this time, and knowing that we have time to discuss that with the board, that's the one, Mr. Gecker, I'd love to spend a lot of time on in understanding now that so many school divisions are going virtual. What is the minimum expectation, even in the virtual setting, in lieu of being in person for 990 hours that we would want to set out to ensure that there's at least a minimum educational experience that every student receives, even in an all remote and virtual setting? And so that's the big area. The other two, testing and accreditation, I think

[01:17:17] more conversations because the timeline on those might be more rapid, but that's some initial thoughts, Mr. Gecker. Thank you. Are there any questions or comments from board members? I just want to say I do appreciate Dr. Lane's leadership and the guidance he's been giving to all superintendents, and it's been very, very clear, and I want to reiterate what he's shared.

[01:17:48] The challenges around the local decisions are the health data and the concern and safety and the ability to follow those guidance, but then also be able to implement when we're seeing such changing data points. And I'll speak for Northern Virginia, when we have to consider the Washington, D.C. metropolitan area data, which also is inclusive of D.C. and Maryland, and many of our families and

parents who work there, and many people who come and go between Northern Virginia and those areas. And so that's been another factor that's been challenging. But

[01:18:25] I just wanted to reiterate that, yes, it's been a very difficult decision. And it's one that localities are dealing with. And I appreciate, Mr. Gecker, you asking what role does this board play in that? Because that's something that I was wondering as well in terms of more clarification.

[01:18:42] And thank you, Dr. Lane, for those suggested areas. But Dr. Lane has been phenomenal and his, and the VDOE team have been phenomenal in giving good guidance. Again, it's just changing data and health concerns that are continual. And we're seeing more and more of that, particularly recent studies that come out and things on the implication for students and children. And so there's a lot. And as many health directors have shared with us, this is something we're just learning about this virus, only having been with it for a few months, really, and trying to understand the implications of that.

[01:19:17] So it's a very, very complex issue, but what guidance that can be given has been given very well. And I think we need to continue to monitor the health aspect of it and see what, and I appreciate what Dr. Lane said about more metrics being created and provided to school systems and working with VDH and local health departments.

[01:19:41] - I wanna add too, I think the last point Dr. Lane noted about just the minimal expectations for what the experience constitutes under virtual. I think that's a very, very important issue that deserves some absolute discussion at this level.

[01:20:00] I certainly, I'm not certain of how in the plans that are going to be coming to VDOE by the 14th of August, how you are having insight on what kinds of structures are being incorporated around the virtual experience where local data may warrant that because that could be consequential in what children are receiving or not.

[01:20:34] Equipment notwithstanding, I mean, even understanding what that is, accessibility under virtual reality, the level of effort that needs to be deployed safely around even a virtual solution, which I do feel that's an area where I certainly hope the board will have an opportunity to appreciate in a more nuanced way what the thinking is around how we're understanding that.

[01:21:09] - Dr. Wilson. - To take that point further and thinking about equity and ensuring that all of our students have the opportunity to continue to progress and advance in whatever format or setting they happen to be in.

[01:21:29] But in the return plan, recovery design, restart plan, there is a section there that talks about return to school equity planning and a number of recommendations that are included. And so I wonder if even asking, I don't know what the plan is for asking divisions to provide information, what that reporting looks like, what that plan is supposed to look like.

[01:21:57] But going back to one of our earlier conversations today, as we're thinking about ensuring that our focus on equity remains consistent and persistent throughout all of this, even knowing that we are all in this unknown territory, how do we provide opportunities to receive as much information as possible about how our divisions are serving all of our students in the best way possible and providing additional guidance and support where necessary.

[01:22:34] So the recommendation, for example, of ensuring that federal dollars are going to address equity gaps is great, but how do we know that that's happening? We know that it's a recommendation and to what extent a division may be able to do it is another question, but are we asking to see some of that information?

[01:22:52] So that would be a point that I would add. Maybe I'll show my screen and tell you what it says now. We can certainly enhance our documents based on the board's feedback. But, Mr. Gecker, do you mind if I diverge on that for a moment? No, I don't mind at all.

[01:23:09] So we did put up instructional plan guidance, and I'm sharing my screen now. Are you seeing a Word document? Yes. So this is how they submit the plan is a different technicality.

[01:23:25] but this is there are two plans that the school divisions must submit one is can you make their health i will yes thank you thank you there's some screens in the way here give me a second

[01:23:41] sorry that's okay uh don't let me stop you keep going no no i i found it sorry is this better yes okay so um so the the school divisions must know the health plan to outline essentially what their

[01:24:16] operational status would look like for uh you know six foot distancing all of the things that we've recommended this is what underpins the instructional plan now they will be more detailed here but i think what you were asking about is identification of instructional gaps in student needs and so they're they're required to identify those gaps they're they were required because we were worried that there might be times they would have to go back to remote learning to have a plan for remote learning but here they are required to do new instruction for all students where

[01:24:52] whereas we did continuity for learning in the spring with because school was technically closed the regardless of their operational status remote or not the schools are open and they are to provide new instruction and so here you can see that we asked them in their plan to describe how they're going to provide new instruction and we said equitably and then we added with attention to vulnerable and special populations. And then we listed those groups out that we specifically wanted to see them highlight. So I'm going to stop sharing my screen, but I think we captured that. But I think that we can take this in our conversations with the board over the next couple

[01:25:31] months to a little bit more detail, because that was really intended to be a phase three plan focused on, you know, a situation where some students were at home and some students were in person and that there would be some hybrid version of that now with so many of the commonwealth students being completely virtual i think we can come back around with some guidance on exactly what the virtual setting uh should look like too and the department's working on that but but that's definitely a discussion on that before you can get the waiver of the 990 hours you know what what are the what are the expectations we have for students and so sorry mr gecker didn't mean to

[01:26:09] go over there but i didn't want the board to see how we're collecting that information we're collecting but we're not approving we're not that's right so i mean it's essentially like having ungraded homework in a way mr gecker dr land i would be interested in seeing how the divisions are the equity question right now because on behalf of all the teachers in high poverty areas and school leaders i feel like i would like to see what's going on so that if my plan might be a little adjustment that I have a full broad set of experiences to draw from to make

[01:26:49] my plan better. James, let me ask you, to follow up on that, would it be possible for staff to brief the board at our September meeting, which I think is the next one, regarding what virtual learning looks like, what different types of, you know, how people are doing, and then with the goal toward the the board at some point issuing guidance as to what it ought to look like.

[01:27:18] Absolutely. Can you do that in September? Absolutely. The instructional plans are due 15 days before the first day of their academic term. And so we don't have that data today because not all of them are within that 15-day period.

[01:27:35] But by September, we will absolutely have that data and be able to provide it to you. Okay. Yeah, I'd like that put on September's agenda. again to Pam's point you know looking at it overall but also looking at it specifically how we're going to do business virtually equitably mr.

[01:27:56] president right James well just in turn yeah yeah I think that's a great idea and really an ongoing expectation of thinking about how we the board can be helpful as you say ungraded homework we may not be ready to grade but to at least review and offer feedback on an ongoing basis on how the divisions are doing specifically with a focus on equity. And even, you know, we don't want to be calling them out on not solving

[01:28:31] things that aren't solvable, but to at least be able to call it out. If the answer is that they aren't pulling it off, then, you know, we need to acknowledge that, that despite the best efforts, we're falling short and then that'll help the wider public discussion about what what what do we do next on that on the on the wider public discussion you know a lot of this comes down to resources as we know and that's not something local divisions can fix um i i think

[01:29:07] reading the newspaper it looks like there may be more money for k-12 coming from the from the federal level and i would hope that we could do anything we can to encourage the state decision makers on how that fund gets spent those funds get spent to put the thumb on the scale for equity and you know really what it comes down to is you know if we're going to do school in person which i think we desperately need to do especially for the younger grades and i applaud the the

[01:29:40] division's guidelines with the the focus in phase two on on k2 i think i think k2 or even k3 4 you could make an argument for bringing them back in person before you bring others back they are less likely the evidence now shows to to spread the disease they're less likely to have more serious consequences they are more likely to suffer educationally if we don't bring them back and frankly, the custodial impact.

[01:30:14] We shouldn't be, we don't need to pretend that part of, but well, we should acknowledge that part of what public education does in the United States is fulfill a custodial role for our younger children that enables parents to go to work.

[01:30:33] And so the equity impact on families, it's not just educational, it's that custodial piece. So if we could get the K to three to four kids back, parents could work and that could have a positive impact.

[01:30:51] So I would love, but how do you do that? Basically what you've got to do, if you're going to distance, you've almost got to double the space and double the staff. And how do you do that? You can't do it without money.

[01:31:06] And so to the extent that we can steer the funds to the neediest divisions to figure out how to expand staff and space. And space, it's not like you can build new buildings, but you can make relationships with the boys and girls clubs or the afterschool programs, or they're all kind of create churches or other underutilized spaces.

[01:31:35] we could do it with creativity if you had resources. The one more thing I'll comment before I build the back is the, Dr. Lane, in thinking about what the board, and Mr. President Gecker, what the board's role is, as you think about how, if more resources do come through, still the divisions aren't going to be suddenly able to hire more licensed teachers.

[01:32:05] just not all going to be out there but is there a way we can authorize them to use other competent adults so I'm thinking staff who are now working in or have in the past worked in before and after school programs could a third grade teacher have a partner in another room and the third grade teacher works with both two classrooms worth but has a competent adult who's able to keep children safe in one room even if he or she is not a licensed teacher you know so it's is there creativity you need from us or you may have the waiver

[01:32:44] authority to lessen requirements for what's it take to have a competent adult safe in keeping children safe in a room even if there's not a licensed educator in the room so I'm rambling but I think the equity impact of this is I echo President Gecker's and others concerns that the equity impact is just potentially huge and that we want I would encourage

[01:33:15] us to be doing everything we can to get especially our lower grade children back in person as soon as possible as much as possible recognizing it may involve some extra risk but with the expectation that we can keep that risk reduced for those younger children and especially in the situation for the students who need it the most it would be you know my goal is hoping to use the information we gather and let's make an assumption that's likely wrong but the assumption just for the

[01:33:52] the working purposes of this discussion is the well-resourced divisions will be able to do it better than the poorly resourced divisions, which frankly is not always the case, but let's make that assumption. By understanding what those people who are doing it well need to do it, we can then actually quantify the needs to have that high quality spread throughout the common world. Whereas right now, we really, I don't know, and James may know, but I don't think even James knows all the different forms, for example, virtual is taking. And it would be helpful to

[01:34:29] know and to understand so that we can disperse that. One of the things that the local people here keep saying is we don't have enough guidance as to how we're doing. We're sort of flying on our own. I don't know how many task forces James is on. I've been on three. We seem to have a multiple you know multiplicity of things to create the guidelines and then when it comes down to the specifics you know it's nice to say well do it safely but then how does it work in the building is a little bit more detailed than the task forces are going into it might be nice to have a clearing

[01:35:05] house through us or through the department that says you know here's how it gets done and here's what it costs and here's what it takes you know to get to your teaching point you know the only thing i would maybe caveat is i think you said less than the standards you know we have talked before uh and i guess previous superintendent of public instruction that talked about a teaching model where you have essentially a master teacher and other personnel uh you know in those areas where you know we haven't had a qualified math teacher for a while as an example where you could

[01:35:41] actually pay more for the master teacher and then have aides basically run you know quarters of classes in order and have that master teacher rotate throughout so part of your suggestion i think is right the you know custodial aspect of it uh you know adults who will keep them safe and be able to move an agenda forward but that does not necessarily to me speak to the educational outcomes got to be less or the experience has got to be less. Truth is that, you know, with the reading assistants, math assistants, etc., we may be able to do more with the teachers that we have

[01:36:18] who are qualified to teach. And this may be an appropriate time to look more seriously at that model as, you know, something we can promote throughout the Commonwealth and particularly those places where it's more difficult to find those master teachers to allow the pay scale to adjusted appropriately. James I know you were about to say something and I probably cut you off.

[01:36:43] Thanks Mr. Gecker and certainly we're happy to be a clearinghouse for specifics. I do think our 3R document that Jamel referenced does have a lot of specifics on how to do some of these things but the one clarification I wanted to make is early on you asked me if we were approving the plans and I said no and then I think the metaphor you used that they were ungraded and I don't know know if I want to use that metaphor, because what I will tell you is we are reviewing and providing feedback on each of the plans. And so I would say we're grading them from a formative

[01:37:21] standpoint, not a summative standpoint. But, you know, I can say that of the 30 we've received thus far, 12 needed feedback and were resubmitted. And so I think that the process of providing technical assistance from the department and guidance is there. And certainly we've been able to help school divisions through some tricky issues when they've asked for our support. I appreciate that. I was really responding to that. I guess at one time we had talked about plans and that got downgraded in the document to reviewing plans. President Gecker. Dr. Wilson. Just one comment. I would assume

[01:38:00] I'm sure that the department is certainly aware and sensitive to all of the things that our divisions are trying to work through. But I will encourage us to be flexible where we can be flexible and say yes, when we can find a reason to say yes, opportunity to say yes, rather than a reason to say no, if we can possibly do that.

[01:38:24] Because sometimes I worry that our systems and our processes are not set up and allow for the flexibility that many of our divisions, especially the smaller divisions that fewer resources may find themselves dealing with alongside larger divisions that have to be flexible in how they use the resources that they currently have.

[01:38:47] So to the extent that our systems can be adjusted and flexible, I would encourage us to do that. - Okay, any other comments on this? - I have one. - Please, Dr. Duran. - Well, clearly there are divisions that are not as funded as others, clearly there's going to be a disparity in that and we have to pay attention to that so and remind us during these economic times we're in in covet even what we would consider quote-unquote some of the well-resourced districts are very much struggling because many of the focus many of the reason they had been well resourced were related to economics that are no longer there and factors

[01:39:27] that are no longer there um you know in northern virginia you have a lot of business tourism you You know, hotels, restaurant taxes that are coming in from the local governments that are no longer there. You have many of those funds not coming in. And so I just, and I'm not saying that doesn't mean there are other districts that are going to be much more impacted than that.

[01:39:47] I just want us to not forget that and say and assume that those well-funded districts are able to do what they need to do. They're actually having a lot of major impact because the resources that had been going to them are dried up.

[01:40:04] and so it's having to look and then within those well-resourced districts particularly i'm speaking of my northern virginia you have pockets of uh communities that have real major economic uh inequities even within their uh district and in their area so i just want us to remember that and i appreciate i'm following up on dr wilson's comment about the flexibility piece and that rang well with me and i just wanted to reiterate thank her for that because i do think that's something we always have to keep in our in our mind there are pockets of inequity and then what we consider traditionally well-resourced is not the same now given the situation we're in in

[01:40:42] covid and the economic impact it's had hey anybody else and thank you for those comments i am not seeing anybody on this topic are there any other topics that uh we would like to address before we adjourn i would just like to publicly say thank you for to dr pexton who's been leading our new committee and we had a meeting yesterday she may want to add details on that but i really yesterday we worked to gather our charge and what we'll be working on and i just wanted to thank her publicly in the meeting for helping bring us together with a charge forward which i think

[01:41:22] will be very beneficial as we understand some of the positive outcomes some of the perhaps potential negative outcomes or unintended consequences of our new standards of accreditation and we are new into this and we have a lot more to learn but the timing right now and i just wanted to thank her she did a phenomenal job of helping steer us in a way that i think will benefit not only the board but certainly uh the greater k-12 community so thank you dr peckson i don't know if you wanted to add any more about what we did yesterday but i know there'll be more to come but i felt it was important for uh the community to know that and no thank you i appreciate you

[01:42:00] saying that and recognizing that I'm excited about the fact the path that we're starting down looking at the standards of accreditation I think yesterday's meeting was a really good level set meeting for the team the team has a lot of respect for the standards as they are in the process that they went through to get to where they are today and I think that that this committee's work is a very proactive example of how we are trying to keep the conversations and the priorities of the board that we are discussing on a regular basis we're trying to make sure that those things are present and relative in the in in the parts of our commonwealth education that matter and

[01:42:39] one of them and so i think this is a very uh forward uh uh leaning proactive way that the board is just really just what we can what we what we agreed to yesterday is really just conducting a pulse check we're just going to be validating that the original positive negative and unintended outcomes that could have come out of the accreditation model as it is today. We just want to make sure that we're doing our due diligence that we're not only giving our attention to any of those early indicators, but we're also reconciling that the board's intent at that time with what our priorities are today. And that's equity and that's quality of instruction

[01:43:18] and education and all the things that we just got finished talking about even relative to COVID. So really excited to get this going. I want to say thank you to my co-committee members that are represented on the board here, to Dr. Duran himself, to Ms. Davis Vought, and of course to Dr. Wilson. I will say that as part of her exciting appointment to the vice presidency, I was selfishly concerned about,

you're still going to be on my standards of accreditation committee, right? And she said, yeah. So I was like, even bonus, because now we have our vice president helping us to really champion an important cause and so i'm excited about the

[01:43:57] work thank you for bringing it up dr dron and we've got a lot to learn together and just a lot to do just to ensure that that model is is serving the commonwealth in its best possible way well thank you uh we look forward to the committee moving forward and to the results from it all right i would like to say thank you to all of the parents and the stakeholders and their public comments that they're sending to the board and i encourage them to please continue to send their messages to us and their letters of concern because i find those to be very enlightening and please please participate in what we're doing please share their thoughts and ideas and

[01:44:34] and together we'll get through this thank you nobody else has any comments i think we're at that point where we are adjourning emily is there anything else i need to do here nope nothing on my end good okay then uh the board is adjourned look forward to seeing you all soon thank you - Thank you everybody.

[01:44:58] - Thank you.